
Discourse Analysis Across Events

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Abstract

Discourse analysis is a research method that provides systematic evidence about social processes through the detailed examination of speech, writing, and other sign use. In a recent book (Wortham and Reyes 2015) and in this chapter, we argue that educational research on processes that occur across events – such as learning, socialization, and identity formation – can benefit from cross-event discourse analysis. This chapter outlines a linguistic anthropological method for doing discourse analysis both within and across events, showing how to study the pathways that linguistic forms, utterances, cultural models, individuals, and groups travel across linked events.

Keywords

Discourse analysis • Speech event • Context • Learning • Socialization • Identity

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Introduction

Discourse analysis is a research method that provides systematic evidence about social processes through the detailed examination of speech, writing, and other sign use. There are several approaches to discourse analysis. Most approaches are concerned with the analysis of single speech events or with the analysis of recurring types of events. Such approaches are valuable, but they cannot illuminate processes that emerge across events. In this chapter, we describe a method for doing discourse analysis across linked speech events (cf. Wortham and Reyes 2015 for a more extended account). This approach draws primarily on the field of linguistic anthropology – a discipline that studies language use in social and cultural contexts. In this chapter, we outline a linguistic anthropological method for doing discourse analysis both within and across events, showing how to study the pathways that linguistic forms, utterances, cultural models, individuals, and groups travel across linked events. These links are implicitly or explicitly created by participants in discourse, and the analyst's job is to trace these links. We discuss how educational research concerned with processes that occur across events – such as learning, socialization, and identity formation – can benefit from cross-event discourse analysis.

Recent theoretical and empirical work has made clear that many important social processes can only be understood if we move beyond single speech events to analyze pathways across linked events (Agha 2007; Agha and Wortham 2005; Wortham 2012). Learning, for example, involves systematic changes in behavior from one event to the next. A learner has experiences in one or more events and then behaves differently in subsequent events. In socialization, to take another example, a novice experiences events characteristic of a group and then participates more competently in future events. Identity formation also takes place across multiple events, with an individual identified as a type of person in one event, then more predictably as that type in subsequent events. No matter how sophisticated our analyses of discrete events, we cannot offer empirically adequate analyses of processes like learning, socialization, and identity formation that inherently take place across events unless we study pathways across linked events. In order for discourse analysis to be a useful method for studying such processes, it must uncover how people, signs, knowledge, dispositions, and tools travel from one event to another and facilitate behavior across pathways of events.

Traditionally discourse analysis has been done on single events or on recurring types of events. Linguistic anthropological approaches to discourse analysis were largely developed for analyzing discrete events, and most of the methodological tools we discuss below come from this earlier work. In this chapter, we discuss how linguistic anthropological approaches have been extended to analyze pathways of linked events over time and illuminate crucial human processes that take place across chains of events. The next section describes traditional work on discrete speech events. Then we discuss discourse analysis across events.

Within Events

The analysis of discrete speech events over the past several decades has been enormously fruitful (e.g., Goffman 1981; Gumperz 1982; Hymes 1964; Sacks et al. 1974; Silverstein 1992). Founding figures of discourse analysis such as Goffman (1981), Hymes (1974), Jakobson (1960), and others have described the central components of any given speech event. Every speech event includes **participants** – a speaker, an addressee, and often an audience or overhearers. It includes a **message**, communicated over some channel that connects speaker and addressee, “encoding” the message in some denotational **code**. The speech and nonverbal signs that constitute the event have an **organization** – at least a beginning, middle, and end, and often more complex kinds of poetic patterning. The communication takes place in some context, both a physical **setting** and a social world with **norms** about social identities and social events. The event has social **consequences** and accomplishes social action.

Speech events in American classrooms, for example, often include teachers and students as participants. The participants and classroom settings are themselves embedded in local cultural contexts within which models of personhood and social norms circulate – for example, models and norms about the “learning disabled” (Mehan 1996), “model minorities” (Reyes 2007), “unpromising boys” (Wortham 2006), “jocks” and “burnouts” (Eckert 1989), and so on. Academic subject matter is one type of message that is communicated through a linguistic code, such as Spanish, and through some spoken or written channel, such as writing on a blackboard. Classroom interaction often has an organization, like the “IRE” (initiation-response-evaluation) routine in which teachers ask questions, students respond, and teachers evaluate responses. In this routine, participants take turns being speaker, addressee, and audience. Consequences of such events include a wide range of possibilities, such as learning new academic content, reproducing social stereotypes, and so on.

Different approaches to discourse analysis prioritize different components and consequences of speech events and offer different accounts of how these components interrelate. Linguistic anthropologists are often concerned with the social functions of speech, and this centrally includes the social identities or positions that participants assign themselves and others. To examine this, a linguistic anthropological approach to discourse analysis depends centrally on a distinction between what Jakobson (1957/1971) called a **narrated event** and an “event of speaking” or **narrating event**. The narrated event is what is being talked about, while the narrating event is the activity of talking about it. Narrated content includes more than just narratives. Any communicative encounter involves a narrating event (the interaction between participants) within which a narrated event (the topics and characterizations that make up a conversation) is discussed. In classroom interaction, for example, the narrating event often involves teachers and students engaging in explication, discipline, or byplay, and the narrated event often involves academic subject matter or explicit instructions for behavior.

When people narrate events, they often **voice** or depict narrated characters as occupying recognizable social positions (Bakhtin 1935/1981; Wortham 2001). Oftentimes this is done using **reported speech**, direct and indirect reports of what a narrated character said. Reported speech connects narrated and narrating events, reproducing and characterizing something from the narrated event to accomplish action in the narrating event. That is, when narrators voice a character they not only **position** that character in recognizable ways, but also position themselves in relation to that character in the narrated event, in relation to other participants in the narrating event, and in relation to groups in the larger social world.

For example, Reyes (2013) describes classroom interactions in which a student, Samuel Jung, is ridiculed with respect to a nickname he has acquired at the school: Samsung Electronics. On one occasion, the teacher and students are discussing sample sentences for their assignment and Samuel Jung interrupts to contest the use of his nickname. In this interaction, the narrating event involves the teacher, Samuel Jung, and other students having an academic discussion, teasing Samuel, and struggling over their right to use the nickname. There are two narrated events: a conversation about the assignment and a struggle over Samuel Jung's nickname. Reyes analyzes how Samuel Jung is assigned a voice partly through reported speech when the teacher offers a sample sentence that Samuel Jung might use to address his classmate Sam: "Help me Sam, my circuit breakers are going." Reyes explores how the teacher uses reported speech like this not only to help establish a recognizable voice for Samuel Jung by comparing him to a piece of faulty electronic equipment in the narrated event, but also to help establish her own positioning as a teacher who controls classroom discussion with a sense of humor in the narrating event.

Reyes' account demonstrates how analysts need to rely on context beyond the speech event even when doing discourse analysis of discrete events. Silverstein (1992, 1993) argues that the central problem in discourse analysis is determining **relevant context**. Relevant context gets established as speakers organize their messages systematically so as to foreground certain aspects and as other speakers subsequently presuppose the same aspects of context. Participants do this largely through the systematic deployment and uptake of **indexical signs** that presuppose or create aspects of context.

An indexical sign signals its object by pointing to it (Peirce 1932; Silverstein 1976). For example, uttering the word "dude" can indexically presuppose a particular type of young male speaker. As a speech event unfolds, indexical signs normally accumulate and point to similar contexts, presupposing certain aspects of context as more and more likely to be relevant. For example, an utterance containing "dude" can co-occur with other signs that mutually reinforce one another, such as looking a certain age, wearing particular clothing, someone replying "bro," and so on. Silverstein (1992, 1993) calls the accumulation of such signs that point to similar aspects of context **contextualization**, the process through which the context relevant to interpreting a speech event is established. Over the course of a discursive interaction, a series of indexical signs may come to presuppose some aspects of the context as relevant. If and when "dude" and accompanying signs have collectively established context that involves a particular young male type, the speech

event has become **entextualized** (Silverstein 1992, 1993). That is, the event has become stable and presupposable as some kind of social action – for example, identifying a speaker as a relaxed, carefree, and confident young male.

The mutually reinforcing processes of contextualization and entextualization depend on the emergence of a **configuration of mutually presupposing signs**, or a “poetic structure” (Jakobson 1960; Silverstein 1992, 1993), a set of signs that collectively establishes relevant context. If more and more signs come to presuppose the social type of a relaxed, carefree, confident young male, these signs lock together in a mutually presupposing structure. Once this happens, speakers routinely infer that a given social type is being invoked. Thus, a pattern of indexical signs comes to presuppose relevant context, and this allows speakers to infer the social types being invoked and the social action being performed.

For example, Reyes (2011) describes a classroom interaction in which a student, Pete, cries “racist” as a teacher is trying to get students back on task after a 10-min break. The use of “racist” emerges not in response to explicit racist language, but in response to more subtle, indexical cues that emerge in a poetic configuration that collectively presupposes a racist stereotype. In the interaction, the narrating event includes the teacher, Pete, and other students. The narrated events include a conversation about student behavior and a conversation about fantasy weapons. The teacher begins by saying he wants to “send somebody to the office.” The teacher and students proceed to collectively and playfully describe weapons that will be used on disobedient students: saying “the hammer,” “the hammer of Thor,” “the sword of light,” “the sword of darkness,” “the sword is dark,” “the blade is black,” and “this is black.” Then Pete cries “racist.” Reyes traces two poetic progressions that establish relevant context and make his use of “racist” intelligible. First, the weapon becomes increasingly dangerous – from being a “hammer” to a “sword” to a “blade” of a sword. Second, the weapon becomes increasingly dark, going from “light” to “dark” to “black.” The unfolding discourse links increasing forms of violence to the darkening of the weapons, ending in “black,” which can be an emblem of a racialized identity. The “racist” cry takes up this emergent configuration of signs by presupposing the implicit indexical link between “black” and “violence,” and thus, it is a bid to entextualize the preceding discussion as invoking a racist stereotype. In her analysis, Reyes considers not only this discrete event but also things outside of this event, such as racial ideologies and the wider practice of crying “racist” in other kinds of events.

It should be clear from the account so far that any adequate discourse analysis must include context beyond the speech event itself. Part of discourse analysis focuses on **co-text**, that component of context composed by other signs in the speech event (“hammer,” “sword,” “blade,” and so on). But co-text never suffices, because relevant context always extends beyond the speech event. Participants and analysts must be familiar enough with the social context to recognize cultural models and the signs that index them. Potentially relevant context is indefinitely large – extending from signs in the same utterance to locally established stereotypes to widely circulating, institutionalized models. So any adequate discourse analysis focuses on contexts beyond the speech event, presupposing models of identity and social life

that are necessary to interpret the significance of indexical signs and determine the type of social action occurring. Discourse analysis across events goes beyond this claim to make a stronger argument about context beyond the speech event: pathways across linked events are central to many social processes and represent an important new focus for discourse analysis.

Across Events

Sometimes discourse analysts have to know what happened in some other event to interpret a discursive interaction, and adequate discourse analyses always presuppose something about models that have been created and learned in other events. Wortham and Rhodes (2015) make this argument more extensively, describing for narrative discourse, in particular, two different types of context beyond the speech event: context beyond the event that is inevitably presupposed even when the analysis focuses on a discrete individual event and context that involves pathways of linked events.

When we ask certain kinds of research questions, discourse analysis can require a unit of analysis that extends beyond the individual speech event to several events linked in a pathway. Many central human processes that educational research is concerned with take place across and not within events. Learning involves increasingly competent participation in social activities across events, with exposure and practice in one event facilitating participation in subsequent events. Socialization requires an individual to develop repertoires of cultural models, skills, and habits across events and apply those repertoires more appropriately across time. Identity formation relies on being recognized as a certain kind of person across events such that an identity becomes increasingly presupposable over time. Few human processes take place exclusively within single events, and most social scientific research explicitly or tacitly studies processes that involve linked events of one kind or another.

A focus on cross-event pathways raises an important question for discourse analysis. If discourse analysis excels at revealing the structure and function of discrete events, how can this research method provide systematic evidence relevant to processes that occur only across events, like learning, socialization, and identity formation? One response is to do discourse analysis across pathways of events, studying the linkages that allow individuals, signs, stereotypes, and objects to travel across events and participate in a social process like learning, socialization, or identity formation. Instead of assuming that a discrete event is pivotal or typical, discourse analysts must use methods for systematically tracing linkages across events and showing how relevant social processes are accomplished across pathways.

Our approach draws on work in linguistic anthropology to conceptualize how pathways of linked events emerge and function. Linguistic anthropologists have studied the **recontextualization** of speech events for several decades (Bauman and Briggs 1990; Silverstein and Urban 1996). Mehan (1996), for example, describes

how a student becomes “learning disabled” as ways of speaking about him move from less formal discussions among educators and parents into more formal documents and diagnostic settings, then into official institutionalized accounts. No one event is pivotal, and the characterizations change in some respects from event to event, but across the pathway of events the student’s identity emerges and becomes durable.

Agha (2007) provides a powerful general theory of cross-event pathways. He starts with the concept of **register**, a model of discursive behavior that links signs – ways of speaking or behaving – with evaluative typifications about people. Only certain kinds of speakers typically say “dude,” for example, and anyone who utters this form seems either like a young male associated with certain subcultures or like someone imitating or ridiculing such a person. Registers are collections of such links, with a set of signs that presupposes some recognizable social type of speaker, hearer, and event. Agha argues that any association between a sign and a typification has a **domain**, the group of speakers who recognizes this linkage. He then explains how these three elements of a register (sign, typification, and domain) change over time as speakers use and re-use signs across events. The domain expands or contracts, and the signs that index a typification, plus the nature of the stereotype itself, change as the register is used over time.

For example, instead of assuming that a speaker who uses “dude” comes from a defined group, we must investigate how the term has been and is being used, across contexts, investigating empirically how the sign, the stereotype, and the domain emerge, solidify, and change. Kiesling (2004) does such an analysis, tracing the various meanings of “dude” across a range of social contexts over several decades. From Agha’s perspective, we must study cultural models and the signs that index them in this way, across pathways of events.

Agha presents two central concepts for describing the emergence and transformation of registers: **speech chains** and **enregisterment**. Empirically, associations between signs and the social typifications they index emerge across chains or pathways of linked events. In the simplest case, someone hears a certain association (“dude” being used by a certain type of young male) and then in a subsequent event uses that term to index a similar social type (while telling a story about such people, for example, perhaps using reported speech to voice a narrated character). A register emerges across such linked events, as sign-stereotype links are established and re-used by members of a growing social domain.

Enregisterment is the process through which recurring signs become linked to social typifications across speech chains. An identity for an individual or a stereotype about a group becomes widely recognized through enregisterment, as larger groups of speakers come to recognize the link between a set of signs and an emerging group. Cultural patterns like registers do not stay stable for a bounded group, as presupposed in many simple theories of society and culture. Instead, links between signs and stereotypes emerge and shift. Participants in interaction must coordinate their heterogeneous repertoires in practice, not draw on a stable set of shared categories (Bourdieu 1972/1977; Rymes 2014). A register emerges and changes as

speakers repeat the use of certain signs across events, indexing presupposed stereotypes that themselves shift over time.

Often a register has evaluative content, construing speakers positively or negatively. Sometimes registers are institutionalized, when schools, governments, or other institutions codify guidelines for usage or disseminate sign-stereotype linkages. These evaluations and institutionalizations can provide stability to a register, but signs, typifications, and domains continue to change, and individuals who come to the register at different points in its history often use it in heterogeneous ways. Analysis of any register thus requires attention to changes that emerge over time. Inoue (2006), for example, describes how a register referred to as “Japanese women’s language” emerged over a century ago in Japan. She traces how the same sorts of speech come to index very different groups of women across decades.

Cross-event chains or pathways constitute a different unit of analysis, larger than individual speech events but smaller and more dynamic than macrolevel sociological essentializations. In order to analyze pathways of linked events, a discourse analyst must study the individual events that make up the pathway. But discourse analyses of processes that concern many educational researchers – such as learning, socialization, and identity formation – must also study how cross-event linkages emerge and solidify.

Discourse Analysis Within and Across Events

Cross-event discourse analysis borrows crucial principles from within-event discourse analysis, but it also has some distinctive characteristics. As Silverstein (2005) argues, the principles for **intradiscursive** entextualization are in many ways similar to those for **interdiscursive** enregisterment. That is, many of the same principles used to explain the solidification of social action within an event can be extended to explain the emergence of registers across events. Configurations of mutually presupposing signs emerge within a discrete event. Similarly, sign-typification linkages across events come to presuppose each other and establish a more robust pathway that has a clear shape and direction. Across a set of linked events, participants signal particular typifications and position others in ways that become familiar and robustly established. As participants across events presuppose the sign-typification linkage, it becomes more durably presupposed. The emergence of sign-typification links across events can be analyzed using the same tools introduced above, identifying configurations of indexical signs across events that presuppose each other and establish more robust pathways that accomplish cross-event processes like learning, socialization, and identity formation.

For example, Wortham (2006) describes the emergence of a robust social identity for several students in an American high school class across an academic year. He traces the emergence and use of signs that come to index a particular identity for individual students across events. In one case he describes, the student’s identity shifts over time as she goes from being a disruptive outcast to a principled dissenter.

The analysis shows how teachers and students establish each of these identities across many linked events by deploying signs that presuppose increasingly relevant context, context that allows participants to infer more and more robustly that the student is a disruptive outcast or a principled dissenter. Within a given event, the identification might be provisional or transitory, but across events certain signs and models of personhood come to presuppose each other and lock together in a configuration that makes the social identity difficult to evade.

As described above, the social action accomplished in an event emerges as relevant context is established, as configurations of signs become organized such that they position narrated and actual participants as accomplishing social actions. When we do discourse analysis on pathways of linked events, something similar but more complicated happens. Table 1 compares discourse analysis within and across events. Discourse analysis across events includes the same general components as discourse analysis within events, but several additional components are required to analyze a pathway of linked events.

Discourse analysis across speech events is similar to discourse analysis of discrete events, focusing on how narrated events and indexical signs create relevant context as signs are configured poetically, thereby establishing participants' positions and social actions. But discourse analysis across events has three additional features. First, when discourse analysis extends across events, analysts must select the events to focus on, identifying which events are linked in a pathway. Linked events become relevant context for each other, often through devices like reported speech, recurring narrated events or other sorts of parallelism. These linked events form a special kind of context, **cross-event context**, that is important to establishing social action both within and across events. Second, indexical signs across linked events provide a more extensive set that can be configured into mutually presupposing structures and thus establish relevant context. In order to explain how social action and social processes are accomplished across pathways of events, analysts must describe a **cross-event configuration of indexical signs**. Third, pathways across linked events can accomplish more complex social processes and more durable results than are typically achieved in single events. Analysts must describe how actions and processes are accomplished as a **pathway of linked events takes on a definite shape**. Discourse analysis across events shows how participants use signs to accomplish a more rigid pathway – establishing robust positioning, social action and social processes – as configurations of signs across events link together and come to presuppose relevant context.

In the first stage of this approach, represented on the first line of the table, the analyst infers which events are potentially linked in a pathway. The process of determining relevant linked events requires inference, and this inference depends on which indexical signs and aspects of context become relevant. Many events might potentially be part of a pathway, and the analyst must examine signs in these events in order to decide which ones are in fact linked. After identifying linked events, the analyst describes the narrated events for each. In the next stage, represented on the second and fourth lines, the discourse analyst engages in the iterative process of

Table 1 Components of discourse analysis within and across speech events (Adapted from Wortham and Reyes 2015)

	Within events: Contextualization and entextualization	Across events: Recontextualization and enregisterment
Narrated Events Serve as Resources	<i>Map Narrated Events</i> Discursive interactions describe narrated events, which communicate content (this communication itself being a type of action) <i>and</i> provide resources for other social action in the narrating event. Mapping narrated events identifies potential resources that may be important to the discourse analysis.	<i>Select Linked Events and Map Narrated Events</i> Narrated events have been established in prior discursive interactions, and these are often presupposed such that they become resources in subsequent events. Analysis must identify linked events that might make up a pathway and map the narrated events within each of these.
Indexical Signs Presuppose and Create Relevant Context	<i>Select Indexicals and Identify Relevant Context</i> Indexical signs point to potentially relevant aspects of the context. Participants and analysts attend to these signs and make inferences about what context is relevant. This is the process of contextualization, in which relevant context emerges for understanding what is happening in the speech event.	<i>Select Indexicals and Identify Relevant Cross-Event and Other Context</i> Indexical signs point to past and future events along the pathway, tying events together. Other events along the pathway are established as a central part of relevant context, through indexical links like reported speech, shared narrated events and repeated evaluations. Focal indexical signs from across linked events point to cross-event context (other events linked in a pathway) and to other aspects of context that become relevant to understanding social actions and processes accomplished across the pathway.
Poetic Configuration of Signs Establishes Relevant Context and Supports an Account of Social Action	<i>Configure Indexicals</i> Not all potentially salient indexical signs point to aspects of context that become relevant, and not all possible interpretations of social action become plausible. Signs are configured poetically, making some of them more salient. Ultimately, a poetically organized configuration of	<i>Delineate Cross-Event Configurations of Indexicals</i> A set of signs and relevant context gets established as indexicals across events are poetically configured, as signs from several events come to presuppose each other. As this cross-event configuration of signs solidifies, it provisionally ends the back-and-forth construal of

(continued)

Table 1 (continued)

	Within events: Contextualization and entextualization	Across events: Recontextualization and enregisterment
	mutually presupposing indexical signs ends the back- and-forth construal of relevant context and possible interpretations, such that one account of social action becomes the most plausible.	relevant context and establishes the social actions and processes that are being accomplished across events, thus establishing a more rigid pathway.
Relevant Context Grounds Inferences about Voices, Evaluations, Positions and Actions	<i>Construe Indexicals</i> Narrated events and indexical signs make certain aspects of the context relevant to interpreting the discursive interaction. Through entextualization, participants construe these signs and contexts, providing possible interpretations of the voicing, evaluation, positioning, and social action occurring in the narrated and narrating events. Rows 2, 3, and 4 are iterative, with the selection of relevant context and the construal of that context shaping each other, until a configuration of signs solidifies and makes one interpretation of the positioning and social action most plausible.	<i>Construe Indexicals and Trace the Shape of Pathways</i> As linked events collectively come to presuppose overlapping relevant context (e.g., relevant stereotypes from the larger society), a pathway becomes more rigid and particular interpretations of social action become more highly presupposable. Instead of entextualization, we have the broader process of enregisterment, with a pathway of events collectively accomplishing some social action and process. This is also a dialectic process, with newly relevant context in a current event providing opportunities for reinterpreting the pathway, while a firmer account of the pathway constrains the context that might be relevant. When cross-event configurations of signs become stable, they make one construal of the action and broader social process most plausible.
Participants' Positions in and across Narrating Events can be Inferred from Relevant Context, and Social Action is Accomplished as Participants Come to Presuppose one Version of What Happened	<i>Identify Positioning and Social Action in Narrating Events</i> Relevant context allows participants and analysts to infer the interactional and evaluative positions being occupied by narrated characters and participants in the narrating event. These	<i>Identify Emerging Cross- Event Actions and Processes</i> Participants and analysts attend to relevant context across events and make inferences about positioning and social action both within and across events. Pathways across events can accomplish more complex, durable social

(continued)

Table 1 (continued)

	Within events: Contextualization and entextualization	Across events: Recontextualization and enregisterment
	positions, together with other relevant context, allow inferences about the types of social action occurring in the narrating event. Inferences are always provisional, but in practice stable interpretations of an event usually come to be presupposed.	actions and processes, like socialization, learning, and social identification. Over time pathways across events become rigid and presuppose certain outcomes, but these can change with future recontextualizations.

identifying relevant indexicals that occur across linked events, then inferring from the relevant context signaled by these indexicals the types of voices, evaluations, and positioning that might be occurring across events. Construals of voices, evaluations, and positioning make certain indexicals salient, but then newly considered indexicals make new construals plausible, in a back-and-forth interpretive process. This dialectic ends provisionally when a configuration of mutually presupposing indexical signs from across events solidifies and establishes some interpretation as most plausible. This cross-event configuration of signs is represented on the third line of the table. In the last stage, represented on the last line, analysts infer the social actions and processes accomplished across the pathway.

Conclusion

This chapter has described a method for doing discourse analysis across events. Discourse analysis across events can enhance educational research on a range of issues, such as learning, socialization, identity formation, instructional practice, and classroom interactional structure. Any event – in an educational setting or otherwise – participates in multiple pathways, and an analyst must often trace a pathway of linked events relevant to the research focus in order to illuminate how the focal object or process unfolds. Discourse analysis across speech events requires analysis of individual events in a pathway, but it also requires three additional steps. Analysts must **identify linked events** that make up a pathway, studying how events become relevant to each other as they become linked through reported speech, parallelism across narrated events, or other devices. Analysts must **delineate cross-event configurations**, studying how indexical signs across events come to presuppose each other and create relevant context that establishes more rigid pathways. Finally, analysts must **trace the shape of pathways**, showing how they become rigid and establish more complex and durable processes like learning, socialization, and identity formation.

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